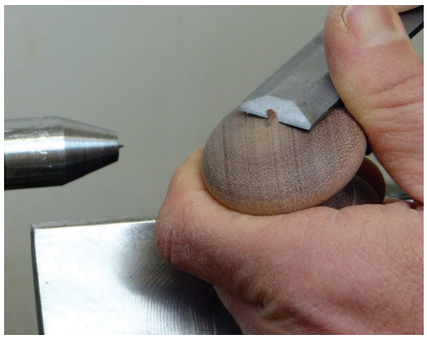
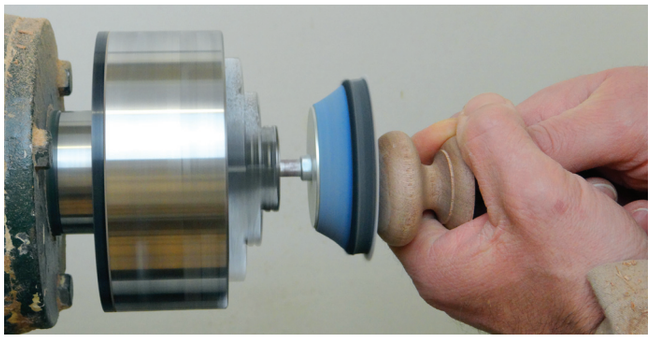


Paring away the nib with a sharp chisel

The chisel cut surface

Sanding away the chisel cut area

The alternative method that I use on a larger run of items, is to mount a sanding arbor in the chuck and power sand the nib away. This method is easier on the hands but care needs to be taken to avoid mis-shaping the work. A firm grip on the work with gentle pressure on the pad, along with continual movement of the work, should give the best results. Check the surface frequently, both visually and by touch. I often use a finer grit on the arbor from the last grit used on the lathe for power sanding. If I finished the work to 320 grit, I often use 400 grit on the arbor to avoid odd sanding scratch patterns.



Power sanding the face

The finished drawer pull

Compression marks

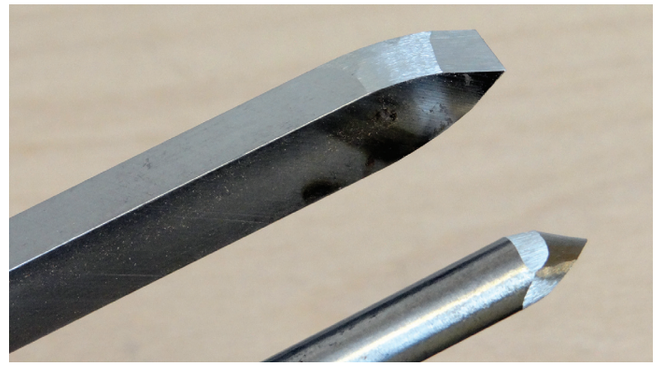
Telltale compression marks on end grain

A common problem with parting off on the lathe is a strange discolouration on the end grain of the work. This usually shows as a pale ring or area close to the centre and is caused by the pressure of the tool's bevel compressing the end grain fibres of the work. Some woods seem to be more susceptible than others to this: sapele and maple are often culprits, I have found. As this is a form of damage to the end grain, it can't be sanded away. The only way to remove it is to cut it away, so it is best to try to avoid it in the first place.

There are three tips I can offer to eliminate this problem. The first is to apply less pressure to the work. As always, if you need to apply pressure anywhere, it should be tool to toolrest, rather than tool to wood.

A second easier solution to this problem (although you will still need to address the pressure to the wood) is to remove or soften the heel of the tool's bevel. This heel is quite harsh on a freshly sharpened tool, but by rounding it or grinding it away completely, it will make the contact between the wood and the tool much more gentle. I do this on my spindle gouges and skew chisels.

The third solution is more indirect, but it can be a great help: leave more waste between the work and the lathe centre. Often these compression marks can be made because you are working in a tight space without sufficient room to manipulate the tool. By leaving more waste it allow you to make the cut in a more natural and fluid action, without unnecessary restriction. I would always recommend leaving at least 15mm of waste, but more is better than less.



Softening the heel of both spindle gouges and skews will achieve a cleaner surface finish on your work

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